

Research Statement
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I am an applied microeconomist with research interests in labor economics and the economics of education. My research primarily focuses on the role of school and family investments in shaping children's development of human capital during the critical periods of early childhood and adolescence. I leverage a variety of quasi-experimental, experimental, and discrete choice methodologies to address policy-relevant questions, focusing on two overarching themes. First, I study how school investments interact with adolescents' beliefs and choices to determine their higher education outcomes. Second, I study how cash transfers during early childhood impact the wellbeing of children and families.

Adolescent Investments and Higher Education Outcomes

The transition from high school to college is crucial for children's later life outcomes, yet little is known about the role of high school educational inputs in developing skills relevant to college coursework. In my job market paper, "High School Teachers and College-Relevant Skill Production: Evidence from ACT Score Value Added," I study the role of high school teachers in the production of college-relevant skills. Using rich administrative data from North Carolina, I estimate the impacts of high school teachers on students' ACT scores, or "ACT score value added." I then evaluate the impacts of ACT score value added on college enrollment and college performance. I find that quasi-random assignment to a teacher with high value added on the ACT test has positive impacts not only on ACT scores, college enrollment and college selectivity, but on a host of college performance measures. Students assigned to English or math teachers with high ACT score value added earn higher freshman college GPAs, are less likely to drop out during or after freshman year, and are more likely to graduate within five years of initial college enrollment. My results suggest that high school teachers have significant scope to influence the accumulation of college-relevant skills.

In a second paper evaluating college admissions test scores in North Carolina, titled "College Admissions Testing and Learning about Ability: Evidence from Strategic ACT and SAT Taking," I study the decision to take multiple college admissions tests in the presence of universal ACT testing. I find that low-income students are less likely than their peers to take the SAT in addition to the state-mandated ACT, and that they improve upon their initial ACT scores by less when doing so. Taken together, these disparities decrease low-income students' rankings in the test score distribution when evaluating students on their maximum score rather than their initial ACT score, as is common practice in U.S college admissions. I provide evidence that income gaps in multiple test-taking are partially driven by differential responses to the ability signal sent by a student's initial ACT score. I show that closing the income gap in multiple test-taking behavior would reduce the income gap in admissions-relevant test scores by roughly 5%.

In "Course Withdrawals and the Path to College Dropout," coauthored with Peter Arcidiacono and Tom Ahn, we study the decision to withdraw from a college course and the subsequent implications for college persistence. Using college transcript data from the University of Kentucky, we show that white, female, upperclassmen, and high-income students are less likely to withdraw from courses that get easier over the course of the semester, and that course withdrawal is correlated with subsequent college dropout even after conditioning on academic achievement. We explain these demographic differences using a dynamic discrete choice model of course withdrawal and college dropout with unobserved types, in which informed students are aware of changes in grade distributions between midterm and final exams and make their course

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withdrawal decision accordingly, while uninformed students make mistakes in course withdrawal which increase the probability of dropout. We use counterfactual simulations to examine potential impacts of increasing the cost of withdrawing or equalizing information about grading practices. Our results suggest that closing information gaps about grading practices is a relatively low-cost intervention with potentially high returns.

Early Childhood Transfers and Family Wellbeing

My second strand of research uses data from the Baby's First Years (BFY) study, a randomized control trial which disbursed monthly unconditional cash transfers to low-income mothers of newborns in the U.S. Transfers began shortly after birth and continued for the first 76 months of children's lives, invariant to changing family circumstances. In "Income Support, Marriage, and Family Stability: Evidence from Unconditional Cash Transfers," coauthored with Lisa Gennetian, Katherine Magnuson, and Kim Noble, we study how cash support impacted marriage and single parenthood of children from birth through age 3. Whether income support programs disincentivize marriage has long generated policy debate, yet it remains an open question whether unconditional cash transfers disincentivize marriage in the absence of embedded marriage penalties. We find that the cash transfers increased marriage with children's biological fathers within a year after birth, had no destabilizing effects on new or existing marriages, and did not increase single parenthood. Despite hypotheses that marriage will benefit children through increased household resources, we do not find that marriage resulted in additional contributions of income from the spouse. Results suggest that income support can support marriage in the absence of embedded marriage disincentives and improve family stability by reducing relationship dissolution.

In "Money or Time? Heterogeneous Effects of Unconditional Cash on Parental Investments," coauthored with Lisa Gennetian, Katherine Magnuson, Hirokazu Yoshikawa, Laura Stilwell, Kim Noble, and Greg Duncan, we study how cash support impacted Black and Latina mothers' monetary and time investments in infants. The effects of the cash transfer on net household income, earnings, and household expenditures were similar for families irrespective of race or ethnicity, even given initial differences in family structure, government benefit receipt, and employment. However, effects on monetary and time investments in children differed. Latino families' child-focused expenditures increased, with no effect on maternal employment or time spent with children. Among Black families, maternal work hours decreased and time spent with children on early learning activities increased, with no effect on child-focused expenditures. Results suggest the ways in which unconditional cash can enable families to flexibly respond to diverse family circumstances and constraints.

In "The Impact of Monthly Unconditional Cash on Food Security, Spending, and Consumption Among Families with Low Income and Young children," coauthored with Lisa Gennetian, Matthew Maury, Laura Stilwell, Katherine Magnuson, Kim Noble, Greg Duncan, Nathan Fox, Sarah Halpern-Meekin, and Hirokazu Yoshikawa, we study how cash support impacted food related outcomes. Government benefits have been found to reduce food insecurity, yet many U.S. households remain financially stretched to meet healthy food needs. The monthly unconditional cash had no impact on food insecurity, food expenditure, receipt of government food program benefits, or use of food pantries. The monthly cash transfer reduced

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the share of household income spent on food and increased spending on food not prepared at home.

Building on my empirical work, I have positioned myself as a scholar contributing broadly to the cash transfer literature through my paper “Unconditional Cash Transfers in Early Childhood: A Scoping Review.” This work, coauthored with Lisa Gennetian and published in *Review of Economics of the Household*, provides one of the first comprehensive reviews of U.S. unconditional cash transfer programs for families with children, highlighting evidence gaps and developing a conceptual framework linking income, parental investments, and child outcomes.

Future Work

The results of my job market paper suggest an important role for teachers in shaping children’s skill development during late adolescence. In future work, I plan to further quantify the multifaceted effects of high school teachers. In my job market paper, I find evidence that the correlation between ACT score value added and teacher value added on students’ school attendance is low. However, marginal improvements in attendance may not reflect noncognitive skills relevant to college enrollment and performance, such as cooperation, persistence, or self-discipline. In future work, I plan to examine how variables available in K-12 administrative datasets can be used to construct college-relevant noncognitive skill measures. Additionally, I plan to evaluate whether high school teachers impact college outcomes beyond academic performance, such as college major choice. I have ongoing access to administrative datasets from two states, North Carolina and Kentucky, which I plan to leverage for this work.

In addition to extending my research agenda on educational investments in adolescence, I plan to continue with a new strand of work investigating the role of schools in diagnosing children with disabilities. In “Class Rank and Student Disability Classification,” with Marie Hull and Maria Zhu, we study the effects of students’ third grade class rank on the likelihood that they are classified with a disability in future grades. Using administrative data from North Carolina, we leverage idiosyncratic sampling variation in school-cohort achievement distributions to separately identify class rank effects from the effects of student test scores. We find that students ranked near the top or bottom of their third grade class are more likely to be classified with a disability in fourth grade, compared to students ranked near the middle. Our results suggest that idiosyncratic, subjective factors play a nontrivial role in student disability classification, with important implications for the allocation of resources and federal protections available to students with disabilities. Next steps for this project include evaluating longer-run disability outcomes through twelfth grade.